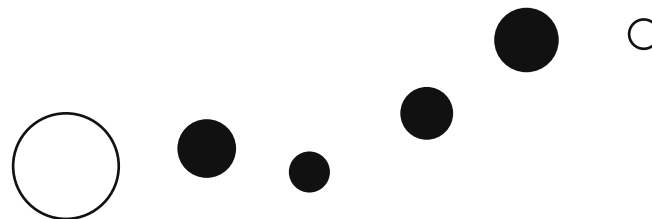


Papier Bleu

No. 1 · January 2015

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No. 1

JANUARY 2015

PROSE POETRY

PAPIER BLEU

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A monthly magazine of prose poetry by Columbia
undergraduates from CC, Barnard, GS and SEAS.

Where to find it. Free, on the steps of Hamilton Hall,
from the first of the month while copies last.

Set in Courier Prime. Printed in New York. 75 copies.

Luca V. (CC '17) grew up on a farm in Ohio and calls home on Tuesdays.

Sofia W. (Barnard '17) puts up peaches every August and counts the lids.

Gabriel J. (CC '15) is a senior who cannot be trusted with a tractor.

Ava W. (GS '15) returned to school after some years away and has opinions about typefaces.

Daniel N. (SEAS '18) is studying engineering and keeps a notebook of footnotes he has not yet used.

A handwritten signature in black ink that reads "Papier Bleu". The script is fluid and cursive, with a small dot above the 'i' in "Papier".

No. 1

JANUARY 2015

Ten writers on memory and omission

MASTHEAD

Founder & Editor-in-Chief

Kristil Rabideau

Papier Bleu is an independent student magazine. It is not an official publication of Columbia University, and the views expressed belong to the writers.

Contributors are listed on pages 17 and 18.

CONTRIBUTORS

Mira S. (GS '16) is from Pennsylvania coal country and has kept the pennies.

Samir T. (CC '16) rides the 1 train home from the library, and falls asleep on it.

Clara K. (CC '16) grew up on the flat part of Kansas and misses the wind.

Ilana M. (CC '18) writes letters she does not send, and one she did.

Kofi T. (CC '18) is from Accra and is learning to like January.

MARAUDE

Daniel N. · SEAS '18

In Maraude the alphabet has a gap in it,¹ and everyone has learned to speak around it.² The old ones say it is only unlit.³

¹ Between K and M. Schoolchildren are taught to leave a breath there, the length of one step on a staircase in the dark.

² Names that once contained the letter are spoken with a pause. Mothers call their children in from the street by calling out the pause.

³ The Registrar of Letters, when asked, produces a ledger in which every letter has an entry. The entry for this one reads, in full: *see above*.

⁴ A clerk sits every night at the foot of the Registry with a blank page and a sharpened pencil. This has gone on for sixty years. The page is blank each morning. The clerk says that is the entry.

⁵ For the full list of people who remember the letter, see note 3.

CONTENTS

Tailings <i>Mira S.</i>	7
Between 28th and 23rd <i>Samir T.</i>	8
Hays, After Harvest <i>Clara K.</i>	9
Water Damage <i>Ilana M.</i>	10
Harmattan <i>Kofi T.</i>	11
Five Messages <i>Luca V.</i>	12
Peaches, Put Up <i>Sofia W.</i>	13
Starting the Tractor in March <i>Gabriel J.</i>	14
The Lamplighter <i>Ava W.</i>	15
Maraude <i>Daniel N.</i>	16

INTERESTED IN SUBMITTING?

Send works no longer than 500 words, in the form of prose poetry. If you are looking for clarity, the best example is Italo Calvino's *Invisible Cities*, or this issue.

Send your work to rabideaukristil@gmail.com.

Please title your email "Papier Bleu Submission" for easy finding.

THE LAMPLIGHTER

Ava W. · GS '15

The lamplighter walks the street at dusk, touching each lamp with his pole. Behind him the vowels go out, one by one, and the words stand dark in their windows.

Th lamplightr walks th strt at dusk, touching ach lamp with his pol. Bhind him th vowels go out, on by on, and th words stand dark in thir windows.

Th lamplghtr walks th strt at dusk, tuchng ach lamp wth hs pl. Bhnd hm th vwls g ut, n by n, and th wrds stand dark n thr wndws.

Th lmpghtr wlks th strt t dsk, tchng ch lmp wth hs pl. Bhnd hm th vwls g t, n by n, nd th wrds stnd drk n thr wndws.

Read it aloud. The lamps will come back on.

STARTING THE TRACTOR IN MARCH

Gabriel J. · CC '15

1. Pick a Saturday. Work your fingers into his gloves, the leather gone stiff and shaped to his hand, the cuffs smelling of diesel and the inside of a barn.
2. Cross the yard past the pear tree, which has been dying politely since 1998. The frozen mud crunches, gives, then holds your boot. Don't look at the kitchen window. Nobody's in it.
3. Knock the wasp nest out of the muffler with a broom handle. Paper gray, light as a wedding invitation. Wasps in March are slow and offended.
4. Prime it. Pull the choke, cold steel numbing the pad of your thumb. Turn the key one notch and listen to the battery think it over.
5. It will not start. Say something to it you wouldn't say in front of your mother.
6. It will start. On the fourth try it catches, coughs, blue smoke going up into the cold, and the whole machine shakes like a wet dog, the seat drumming through your coat, your hands buzzing to the elbow, and the field in front of you, black and wet and steaming a little where the sun hits it, is as big as last year.

TAILINGS

Mira S. · GS '16

Past the Sheetz in Shamokin the road splits a hill that is not a hill but what the mine coughed back up: black slag, loose and clinking underfoot like a pile of broken plates, birches rooted in it at a lean. In July it gives off heat the way a stovetop does an hour after supper, and the air above it wobbles and smells of struck matches and wet pennies. My uncle says the county is hollow underneath, a loaf somebody tore the middle out of, and when a truck goes by on 61 you feel it in your back teeth. The creek runs orange. It leaves a rust ring on the rocks and a taste of nickel on the lip, and nothing lives in it, and the summer I was nine we swam in it anyway, and my feet came out the color of a penny and stayed that way until school. He kept a coffee can of pennies on the dashboard, sticky with Pepsi. He kept the Phillies on the radio through January, when there were no Phillies, only a man reading out the standings of a thing that wasn't happening, and my uncle nodding at each number with his thumb tapping the wheel.

BETWEEN 28TH AND 23RD

Samir T. · CC '16

and the whole car smelling of wet wool and hot brakes, and the man across from me eating a whole rotisserie chicken out of the bag with great tenderness, the way you'd feed a bird that had fallen asleep in your hands, and the girl asleep on her sister's shoulder with one shoe off and the shoe sitting on the floor of the train like it was waiting for its stop, and I think of my mother's kitchen in Dearborn the Thursday before Eid when every surface had a tray on it, trays on the dryer, trays on the radiator, a tray of ma'amoul on the piano nobody played, flour on the cat, the whole apartment smelling of orange blossom and something scorching a little, always something scorching a little, my aunt on the phone saying yes yes it's fine it's fine, and the train goes into the dark between the stations where the lights flicker and all of us look up at once, like a congregation, and then the lights come back and the man has finished the chicken and folds the bag in four.

PEACHES, PUT UP

Sofia W. · Barnard '17

Makes seven quarts, or one August.

1. Cut an X in the bottom of each peach. The skin gives a small wet click.
(Her thumbnail, always, a half-moon of dirt under it.)
2. Drop them in boiling water for forty seconds. The kitchen smells of the inside of a sun hat. Slip the skins off under cold water; they come away like wet silk, the flesh slick and warm in your palm.
(The window fan pushing hot air across the room.)
3. Pack them cut side down into jars. Pour in the syrup, a cinnamon stick in it, and tap out the bubbles with a butter knife until the glass rings thin.
(A wasp walking the rim of the bowl.)
4. Lid, ring, finger-tight. Into the canner, and stand back from the sweet steam that fogs your glasses. After twenty-five minutes lift them onto a towel and leave the room. Listen. One at a time, from the dark of the pantry hall, each lid goes tink as it seals.
(Seven. Count again.)
5. In February, open one. It smells like August with the windows shut, and the syrup runs off the spoon the color of a lamp. Eat it standing at the sink, juice running to your wrist.

FIVE MESSAGES

Luca V. · CC '17

TUESDAY, 6:12 A.M. It's Dad. Call me. It's nothing. Call me when you're up.

6:40. Don't call yet, Mrs. Pruitt's here with a casserole. Nobody died. It's a good casserole. I don't know why she's here.

9:03. *[wind, a screen door]* I'm out at the barn. The gray cat had them in the hay, six, I counted twice. Your mother says I should let you sleep. So that's the news. Six.

9:05. Forgot to say. The well's fine.

11:30. Never mind about calling.

WEDNESDAY, 5:50 A.M. It's Dad. Call me. It's nothing.

HAYS, AFTER HARVEST

Clara K. · CC '16

FOUR O'CLOCK. After harvest the fields outside Hays are the color of a lion's back and about as forgiving. The stubble lies in long stripes that crackle under a boot like cellophane, a hawk on every third fence post, and the grain elevator stands out of the flat like a church that has lost track of its denomination. The afternoon is so hot the latch on the Dillons' pasture gate burns the palm, and the gravel throws the light back up under your chin, and the wind carries diesel and chaff and, from the kitchen, bacon grease.

SIX. The light goes long and orange. A boy goes down the section road on a bicycle with a fishing pole ticking against the spokes, tires hissing in the loose gravel, though the nearest water is a stock tank two miles off with a dead calf in it. He is fourteen, and the only moving thing in a hundred square miles.

EIGHT. The stubble ticks as it cools. A screen door sighs.

NINE. Heat still rising out of the road like breath off a sleeping animal. Crickets.

TEN. Bare soles on the blacktop, warm as bread.

WATER DAMAGE

Ilana M. · CC '18

Dear Ruth,

The apricots came in all at once this year,
[] on the porch in colanders, split and
sticky and humming with wasps, and Walt has
stopped speaking to the neighbor over the matter
of the ladder. I told him a ladder is a ladder. He
said that's []. The creek is down to a
string of puddles you could step across []
and the heron stands in the biggest one like a man
waiting to be called into an office.

I found your father's [] behind the
freezer. I have not moved it.

It rained Tuesday, finally, ten minutes, and the
whole yard smelled like [], and Walt stood
in the door with his hat in his hand and I thought,
there he is, there is the man I [].

Write soon. Bring the good scissors.
Your Aunt Pearl

*Found in a kitchen drawer. A glass of water had stood on
it for some time.*

HARMATTAN

Kofi T. · CC '18

In December the harmattan comes down from the
Sahara and lays a lid of pale dust over Accra, and
the sun goes small and white as a communion wafer
you can look straight at. Laundry on the lines in
Osu stiffens into boards. Every car wears a fur
coat of red-gold powder, and the boys write their
names in it with one finger, and by evening the
wind has rubbed them out. My grandmother works
shea butter into my knuckles, her palms dry as
paper, and says the air is thirsty and we are what
it drinks. Grit in the bread, grit between the
teeth at supper, my lips split and tasting of
copper. I am writing this in a dorm in New York in
January where the radiator knocks like a man
wanting back in, and the snow outside is the
cleanest thing I have ever seen, and I keep licking
my lips to see if it tastes of anything.